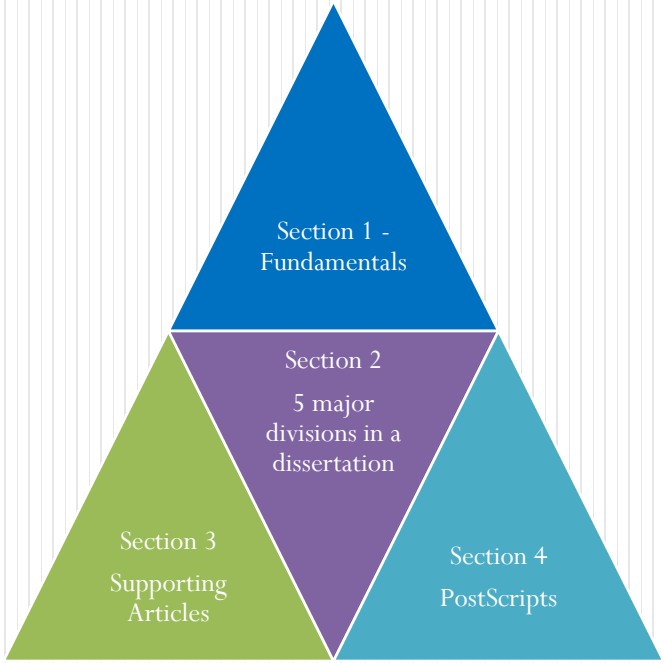
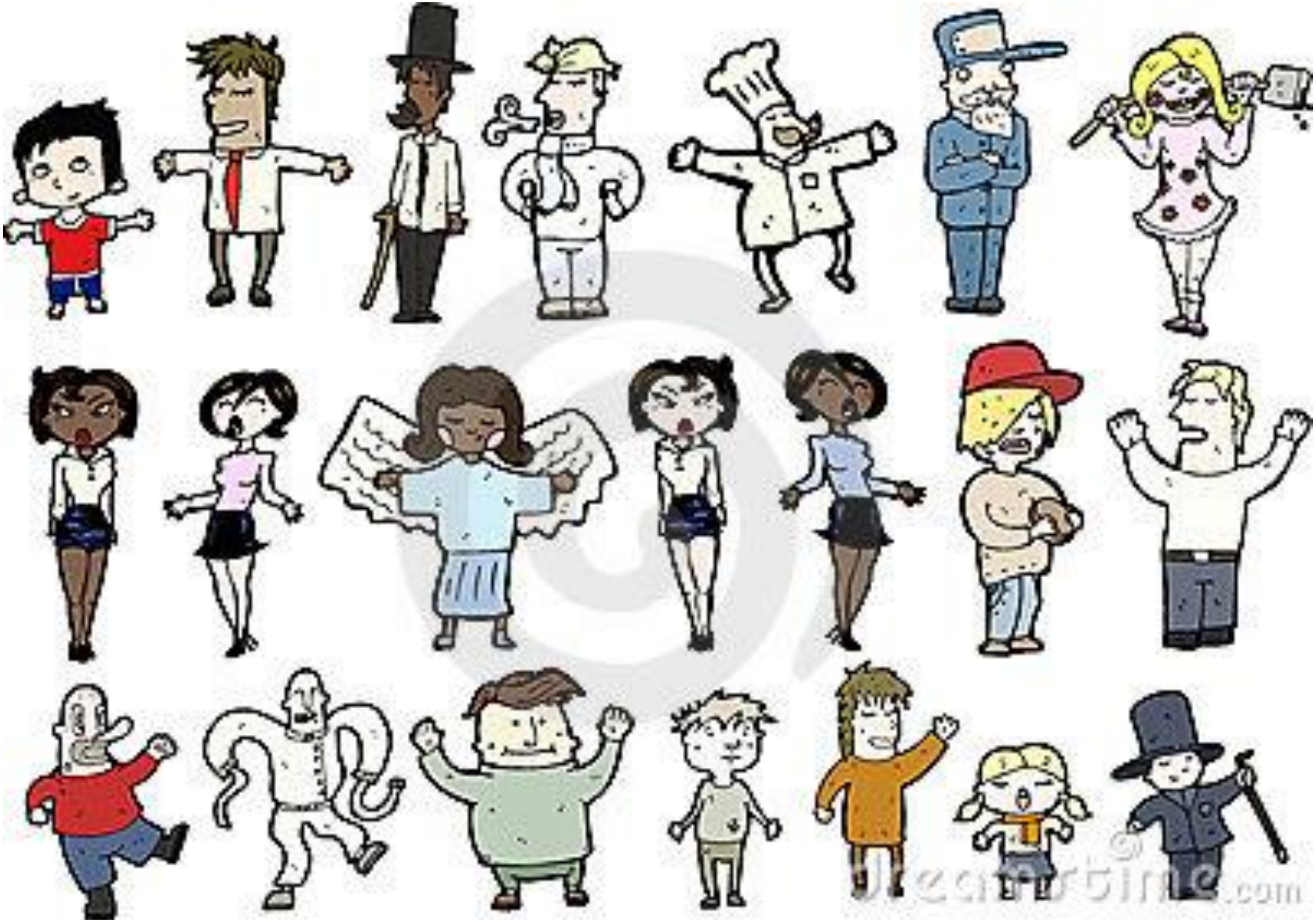
Foundation 9

Supervisors

Session 1.4



Other than you, no one will make as big a contribution to the quality of your dissertation as your supervisor. Getting along in an amicable and professional matter helps – a lot.



Supervisors

- Supervisors comes in all shapes and sizes and differs philosophically and the way that they manage the process.
- Some supervisors prefer
  - a hands-off approach,
  - to micro-manage,
  - to be friendly,
  - some are sociable,
  - others are all business.

Managing the relationship

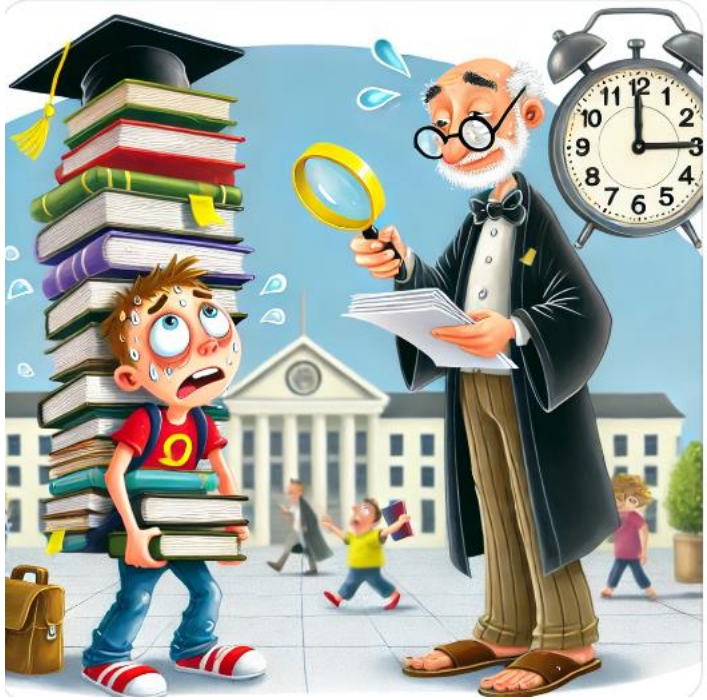
- Have respect! Your supervisor has your fate in his hands – an alienated supervisor won't help you finish quickly.
- Your supervisor should preferably not be your best friend – but treat you professionally like a good friend.
- It is your responsibility to take the lead in the relationship. You should plan the dissertation, set the pace, and keep your supervisor in the loop. You must take the control.

Managing the relationship

- In order to manage the relationship, you should:
  - Know your own weaknesses and strengths and share them with your supervisor (without turning it into a therapy session).
  - Take responsibility for your dissertation process.
  - Don't waist your supervisor's time with unnecessary meetings.

- Keep your supervisor posted with your progress using e-mail communication.
- Keep to agreements and deadlines. Schedule regular meetings where you:
  - Plan the meeting well in advance
  - Put everything you want to discuss on paper.
  - Make notes during the meeting.
  - After your meeting, send a follow up of the meeting.
  - If you need a supervisor to read something before the meeting, send it at least 3-4 days before the meeting.

- Spend time to make drafts that you hand in relatively ‘decent’.
- Take criticism constructively.
- Make agreed on changes immediately.
- Be honest in your relationship with your supervisor.
- Make your supervisor feel he/she is appreciated.



Advice

- Always be open to advice from your supervisor. They 'know' how an external will look at the work and therefore give you the best advice.
- Remember your goal is to hand in a dissertation for examination – not to win a battle with your dissertation on non-significant differences.
- Exception: in fundamentals.

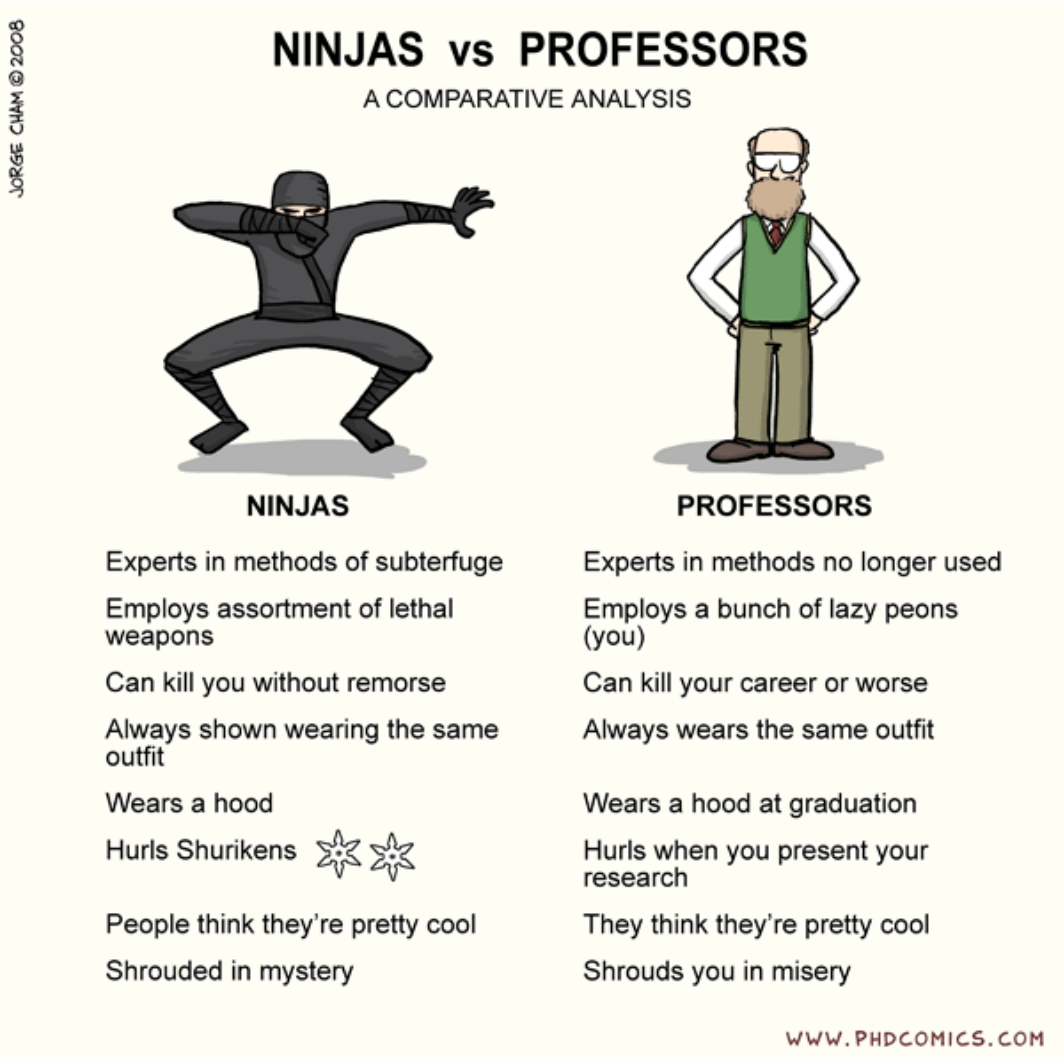
The odds are close to zero that anyone will query you later about the point in your dissertation that you and your supervisor disagree about. If the disagreement causes a major breakdown in the relationship, the cost of sticking to your guns is probably more than you want to pay.

Conflicts

- Plainly but diplomatically discuss problems with your supervisor.
- If nothing can resolves the conflicts, find a 'graceful' way out of your relationship
- Remember – when two elephants fight – it is the grass that suffers.

Use any tools that you have to your disposal and create an InfoGraphic for your supervisor in your group …

It is much better to have a weak proposal rejected than to have it accepted.



To session 1.10